

Beijing 2008 **WRESTLING**

The second chance HERO

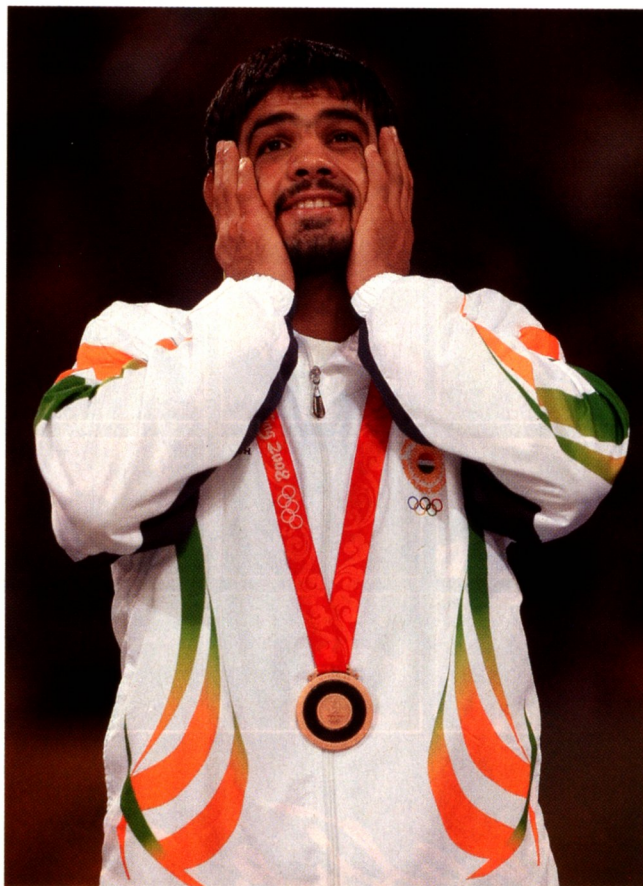
As repechage is introduced for the first time in Olympics wrestling, an Indian turns his luck to bag a bronze medal

The word 'repechage' means 'second chance' in French. At the Olympic Games, where our hard-luck stories can be compiled into PhD theses, an Indian grabbed his second chance with rough, bear-sized hands and changed his life forever.

It is almost sweetly poetic that the country's second medal in Beijing should come from the sport that gave India its first-ever individual medal. Wrestler K.D. Jadhav, bronze medalist in Helsinki, would have approved of his successor. Sushil Kumar, 25 and 5ft 4 inches, built like a teakwood chest of drawers rather than streamlined elite athlete, told his dazed and disoriented countrymen that once he made it into the repechage round of the 66 kg class, he wasn't going to leave the China Agricultural University gymnasium without a medal.

The first thing that wrestlers learn to do, after all, is to find a grip and never let go.

Sushil's medal came in from the cold, well after the obituary of the man who won it had flashed down the news wires to his homeland announcing that he had "crashed out".



AP PHOTO/DAVID GUTTENFELDER



I DID IT: Sushil Kumar with the Bronze medal in Beijing Olympics

SON OF AN MTNL BUS DRIVER, KUMAR'S DAILY DIET CONSISTS OF 3-4 LITRES OF MILK AND VEGETABLES.

Instead, the wrestler from the Satpal *akhara* in Delhi, won three bouts in the next 90 minutes to finish one of only four men on the podium. Silver medallist from the 2007 Asian championships, Sushil is the son of an MTNL bus driver. His sport, he said, needed modern medical inputs and financial support. His daily diet consisted of 3-4 litres of milk and vegetables cooked in ghee. "I know my father can't afford it, but he made sure I never lacked for anything."

There were a confluence of almost karmic circumstances at work: this was the first time the repechage format has been introduced into Olympic wrestling, replacing the old round robin format that placed wrestlers in groups. In the repechage only those defeated by the two finalists get a shot at the bronze, and they must beat one of the two losing semi-finalists. After losing to Andriy Stadnik, Sushil might well have cheered for him from the sidelines. Just before his bronze medal

bout against losing semi-finalist Leonid Spiridonov of Kazakhstan for bronze, Sushil was close to exhaustion, but so was his rival. All that mattered was hunger and India's best Olympic achievers are all born hungry.

A British statistician has recently concluded that athletes born under certain zodiac signs were more likely to succeed in specific Olympic disciplines. Sushil Kumar is a Gemini, born May 26. Under Indian astrology, though it could well be that the unknown wrestler who brought a success-strapped country its most unexpected Olympic prize yet, is most influenced by the sign that overlaps his—Taurus the bull. ■